

GOLDEN CHARIOTS

With Indian luxury trains being ranked among the best in the world, the romance of the Raj and rail is a winning combination. With a new one set to begin operations, the tourist rail track is on a roll.

■ By Nirmala Ravindran

With the jet set and their, well, jets, and today's harried businessmen and top executives perpetually racing against time, who could imagine that an extended rail journey would prove, somewhat literally, a runaway success. Judging by the response to India's luxury trains, clearly the romance of the rail still appeals to a growing and affluent clientele. Sample this: there are no bookings available on The

Palace on Wheels for 2008 while another luxury train, Deccan Odyssey, will be as difficult to board. More importantly, The Society of International Railway Travellers has rated them both among the top 25 trains of the world. The other Indian train to make it to the list is the charming Raj-era narrow gauge toy train—the Darjeeling Himalayan Railway.

According to the President of the US-based Society of International Railway Travellers, Eleanor Hardy, "The list of world's top 25 trains is

PALACE ON WHEELS

ITINERARY: Delhi-Jaipur-Jaisalmer-Jodhpur-Sawai Madhopur-Chittaurgarh-Udaipur-Bharatpur-Agra-Delhi

TARIFF: Rs 1,54,271 per person for a seven-day journey

AMENITIES: 14 AC saloons with attached baths, two dining cars, lounge, bar, library with guided tours and lunches

PURUSHOTTAM DWIVAKAR

